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STEP UP YOUR RETRO GAME: SIX STEPS

STEP 1: OPEN THE RETROSPECTIVE

Activity: Ask for a word, number, or other answer to a question.

- ☐ If the sprint were a ride at Disney World, what ride would it be?
- ☐ What animal might the last sprint be?
- ☐ If the last sprint was a movie, what movie would it be? (or genre)
- ☐ How would you rate the sprint, on a scale from 1 (poor) to 10 (great)?
- ☐ What two words describe the last sprint for you?
- ☐ For you, what color was the last sprint?
- ☐ If you had to graph the last sprint, how would you graph it? Encourage team members to sketch it on a piece of paper or just show it with their hands.

Outcome: This invites everyone to connect with the last sprint; cast their minds back and be ready to reflect together.

Your notes about Step 1: Open the retro

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STEP 2: GATHER DATA

Activity: Review feedback of some kind on how the last sprint went for everyone.

Stop, Keep, Start: Have three areas of the board, each labeled with one word: Start, Stop, Keep. Add questions if you would like more guidance for the team:

- ◻ What should we stop doing?
- ◻ What should we keep about what we're doing?
- ◻ What should we start doing? What should we try doing?
- ◻ Another example using one-word/short phrase categories: Liked, Lacked, Longed for, Learned

Three Little Pigs: Have visuals to represent each kind of house the pigs built.

- ◻ House of straw: it's weak and the wolf can blow it down easily. What activities or habits do we have that make us weaker? What should we stop doing?
- ◻ House of sticks: it's stronger, but we should focus on improvements to make it even more sturdy. What can we improve upon in the team? What can we change?
- ◻ House of brick: it's solid and the big bad wolf can't hurt it. What do we do that is awesome and deserves recognition? Where are we rock solid?
- ◻ If you like, include a 4th visual of the big bad wolf himself, and ask: What is coming that will try to knock us over? What in the future are you concerned about?

Sailboat: Draw or find an image of a sailboat and have four sections of a visual board that relate to parts of the boat.

- ◻ Sails: What pushes us forward? What helps us succeed?
- ◻ Anchor: What drags us back? What did not go well this sprint?
- ◻ Storms: What problems are on the horizon? What do we anticipate coming up?
- ◻ Sun: What gives us energy? This may be a place for appreciation or recognition of positive work.

Plus / Delta Δ: This format only has two categories, which can be helpful if you have limited time or want a more focused retrospective. Provide space for the two sections:

- ◻ Plus: What is great about the sprint?
- ◻ Delta: Δ is the Greek symbol for change. What would we like to change for the next sprint?

Spiderweb Retrospective or Radar Chart: This format helps you measure and collect feedback about specific items. You can measure anything you want, for instance, you could examine:

- ◻ How well your team is demonstrating the five scrum values
- ◻ A variety of positive team traits, like collaboration, communication, motivation, customer focus, meeting culture, or self-improvement
- ◻ Each of the scrum events from the past sprint
- ◻ Or, simply questions like "How easy it is to find things on the website? How easy is it to contact human resources with problems? How easy is it to have technology issues fixed? How easy is the reimbursement process?"

How to conduct a spiderweb retro:

1. You can choose any number of things to measure, but have at least four.
2. You will need a visual space on which to work, blue tape if you are in person, and markers and stickies for each person.
3. In the space, draw lines that cross at a center point so that it looks like bicycle spokes. For every two things you will measure, you need one line (two spokes). If you are in person, use blue tape on the wall or on the floor to create the

scaffold.

4. Label each spoke with something you wish to measure.
5. Draw five slash marks along each spoke, equidistant from each other, and label with whatever numbers you'd like to use.
6. Tell the team they will rate each of the items based upon how much the team showed that quality during the past sprint. Before they begin, discuss what each of the numbers means.
7. Invite everyone to rate the past sprint using stickies or some kind of mark.
8. Draw the web by connecting the average responses along each spoke together.

Outcome: Consider data on how the team feels the last sprint went.

Your notes about Step 2: Gather data

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STEP 3: DISCUSS & GROUP

Activity: Look at data together and group it on the board to visualize patterns.

Your activity that gathered data will guide how you group it and find patterns. You may do one of the following:

- ☐ Focusing on a section at a time, move stickies around so that similar ideas are grouped together. This would be appropriate for activities like Plus / Delta or Three Little Pigs.
- ☐ Focusing on one section at a time, average numbers from each spoke if you used a Spiderweb Retrospective or Radar Chart.

Outcome: See areas where there is most feedback from the team and find patterns.

Your notes about Step 3: Discuss and group

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STEP 4: PRIORITIZE ITEMS

Activity: Facilitate deciding as a team which items are most important to focus on for the next sprint.

- ◻ First, notice any trends that have appeared by grouping the data. What problems have come to light that may be something the team can improve upon? Invite the team to help highlight what priorities have emerged. Don't read the post it notes, but call out patterns, like "looks like most of you don't feel confident in our launch date, who would talk more about that?"
- ◻ The team now needs to figure out what they want to bring into the next sprint as an action item. While you can simply discuss them, you want to encourage all voices instead of allowing the loudest voice to have the most votes. You can do this by dot voting or some other way of electing an item without bias to find what the team would prefer to add as an action item for the next sprint. Remember, it's not a laundry list of what needs to be done differently; we're choosing one or two high priority items to carry into the next sprint so we can continue to inspect and adapt.
- ◻ Once the team has selected what to do, the prioritized item(s) should now get treated like a backlog item; decompose it into smaller tasks, so that we can add it to the backlog and get it "done."

Outcome: Identify the most important items to do differently and make a plan to improve.

Your notes about Step 4: Prioritize items

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STEP 5: ACTIONABLE TASKS

Activity: Facilitate visibility into the action items so that the team can hold themselves accountable for making the changes they identified. Consider asking the team the best way to make visible the improvement items. You could:

- ☐ Add them to the backlog as suggested
- ☐ Make them into a SMART goal (What are SMART goals? The SMART in SMART goals stands for Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-Bound. Defining these parameters as they pertain to your goal helps ensure that your objectives are attainable within a certain time frame.)
- ☐ Post them in a team area

Ensure that all tasks have an owner, date by when they need to be completed, and are visible to all. Commit as a team to checking in and holding each other accountable.

Outcome: Identify the most important items to do differently and make a plan to improve.

Your notes about Step 5: Actionable tasks

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STEP 6: CLOSE THE RETRO

Activity: This step closes out the retrospective. It works well to have an opening that orients the team to the retro and then to bookend the event with an activity to bring closure and send the team back to work. You could even use the same kind of activity to reflect back to the opening and it's fine if this takes only a moment or two. Get feedback on how the retro went and, if desired, on the structure of the retrospective. Possibly include appreciation for teammates. Possible activities include:

- ☐ Fist of 5: how do you feel the retro went? Hold up numbers from a 1 (not that well) to 5 (spectacular).
- ☐ One word: What's one word that summarizes how the retro went for you?
- ☐ Roman voting: How did the retro go for you? Thumbs up, sideways, or thumbs down.

Outcome: Examine information to help adapt retros for the future, possibly also a stronger team due to effective retro and appreciations.

Your notes about Step 5: Actionable tasks